

For instance, one of the markers that Manmohan has set for Gilani is action against the Jamaat-ud-Dawa supremo Hafiz Mohammed Saeed, who India believes is the mastermind of the Mumbai terror attacks. During his talks with Gilani, Manmohan was emphatic and told the Pakistani premier: "Hafiz is a villain of peace, action against him will bring in trust in the relationship." Gilani said that he would do all he could to bring the perpetrators of Mumbai to justice. "Let's not get stuck with nomenclature, we will work out a new template for dialogue. But we have told Pakistan that terrorism remains our core concern and that must be addressed," Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao told INDIA TODAY.

So post the Thimpu thaw, there are two big changes in the relationship: first, shunning the seven course composite dialogue process, and second, both countries will explore the political nature of the dialogue where specific steps will be taken in a brick-by-brick effort to build and boost trust. In this process, there is a possibility of direct dialogue between the intelligence chiefs of the two countries and also with the Pakistan Army to discuss issues of mutual concern. Besides, people-to-people ties will be encouraged, and both sides will refrain from attacking each other at key international forums. A tall order, and even though all issues will be on the agenda, India would continue to track progress on the issue of terrorism. The foreign secretaries of the neighbours are scheduled to meet later this month in Islamabad and this will be followed by a meeting of foreign ministers in the middle of the year.

The second big change is that India now believes that after a long, fragile political interregnum in Pakistan, Gilani, with the army behind him, may be able to deliver on his promises. Even though senior officials in the Government say that it is a calibrated engagement and India will assess it at each step, the new approach remains riddled with optimistic assumptions and the likelihood of dangerous consequences. First, the possibility of Gilani

delivering on his promises is closer to wishful thinking than it is to hard-headed expectation. Now that Manmohan has told him that Hafiz Saeed is the villain of peace, a big trust booster will be a Pakistani action against him, which will express some sense of Islamabad's desire to deliver. But analysts are sceptical about any new move. "This dialogue is doomed

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"Terrorism remains our core concern and that must be addressed by Pakistan."

NIRUPAMA RAO, Foreign Secretary

to fail as it is based on a false premise that Gilani can deliver on his promises on terrorism. It is the army that calls the shots and even the US deals with them. The focus will shift from the issue of terrorism," warns former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy.

The other worry is that there may be a sense of complacency in the Indian establishment about seeking concrete results on terrorism. Because the template is different it will be as good as business as usual, which will put less pressure on Islamabad to act. This is dangerous given that India's key demands seeking action against 26/11 perpetrators have still not been met and the red lines drawn by India on dismantling the terror infrastructure are still up. The mood in Pakistan is also cynical. Although Pakistan's Foreign

Minister Shah Mahmood Qureshi declared soon after Thimpu that it "has exceeded our expectations," there is a belief that the Indian establishment has still not invested fully in the talks process and has been forced into this by external pressure rather than by any internal compulsion. "They have some legitimate issues regarding the Mumbai attacks but it is very unlikely that they will get what they really want from Pakistan, which is handing over of Hafiz Saeed and (Lashkar-e-Toiba operative Zia-ur-Rehman) Lakhvi," says one foreign office insider. "So, they will see no reason to move on other issues."

On the other hand, the Pakistani establishment—which includes the military—also sees no reason to go down on bended knee for any breakthrough. Moreover, the army, under its chief Ashfaq Parvez Kayani, has reverted to its traditional view of India as the main threat to the country. What has added to the complication is Pakistan's serious water crisis, which it claims is being exacerbated by India's alleged contravention of the Indus Water Treaty. Pakistan has decided to seek international arbitration with respect to the Kishanganga Dam being constructed by India on the Chenab River. In fact, representatives of militant organisations operating in Kashmir such as the umbrella group United Jihad Council's Syed Salahuddin are now regularly raising the water issue as a major concern. "If you look at the rhetoric about Kashmir," says Zafar Abbas, resident editor of *Dawn* "you will see that we are almost back to that of 1947, where Kashmir was labelled Pakistan's jugular. The water issue has transformed it in substantive terms from merely a territorial or people's right-to-choose dispute."

While the calibrated engagement may be the new buzzword, unless both sides sustain the engagement with concrete deliverables it will be another futile exercise with dangerous consequences.

with inputs from Hasan Zaidi in Karachi